Global Subscription Video Streaming Market: Competitive Landscape 2023–2026

1 Executive Summary

The global subscription video streaming market between 2023 and 2026 has shifted decisively from subscriber acquisition to monetization and consolidation, with Netflix maintaining dominant scale at over 325 million subscribers [1] while the competitive field narrows through mega-mergers—most notably Skydance Media's acquisitions of Paramount Global ($8 billion) and Warner Bros. Discovery ($111 billion), creating a combined entity with over 200 million streaming subscribers [2, 3]. The global SVoD market is projected at approximately $98 billion in 2026 [4], though broader definitions encompassing AVOD and FAST channels push estimates above $200 billion [5]. North America accounts for roughly 40% of revenue but is approaching saturation at 96% household penetration [6], while Asia-Pacific delivers the fastest growth at an estimated 16.8% CAGR through 2031 [5].

Three interconnected trends define the competitive dynamics. First, ad-supported tiers have become central to streaming economics: 40% of Netflix accounts and 44% of Disney+ accounts now use ad plans [7], transforming advertising into a co-equal revenue stream alongside subscriptions. Second, password-sharing crackdowns delivered a powerful but finite growth impulse—Netflix alone converted roughly 70 million new paid subscribers across 2023–2024 [8, 9]—but net additions fell sharply to 23 million in 2025 as the one-time conversion pool depleted [10]. Third, live sports rights (notably the NBA's $76 billion deal across Disney, NBCUniversal, and Amazon [11]) and cross-platform bundling (with the Disney+/Hulu/Max bundle achieving a 59% 12-month retention rate [12]) have emerged as the primary tools for reducing churn in a market where new U.S. subscribers fell 33% year-over-year in 2025 [13].

The strategic imperative has shifted: future winners will be platforms that most effectively monetize existing subscribers through advertising, pricing power, and content efficiency—particularly non-English-language originals, which now constitute the majority of Netflix's new TV output [14]—rather than those pursuing raw subscriber growth in increasingly saturated Western markets.

2 Introduction

The global subscription video streaming market has undergone a fundamental transformation between 2023 and 2026, shifting from a growth-at-all-costs era to one defined by profitability, consolidation, and strategic monetization. What began as a crowded field of well-funded competitors racing to acquire subscribers has matured into an industry where pricing power, advertising revenue, live sports rights, and content efficiency determine winners and losers. This report examines the competitive positioning of seven major platforms —Netflix, Amazon Prime Video, Disney+, Max (formerly HBO Max), Paramount+, Apple TV+, and Peacock —alongside market sizing, regional dynamics, and the structural trends reshaping the industry through 2026.

The period's most dramatic development has been mega-consolidation: Skydance Media completed its $8 billion merger with Paramount Global in August 2025 [2], and then acquired Warner Bros. Discovery in October 2026 for approximately $111 billion, forming a new entity called Skydance Corporation with over 200 million streaming subscribers [3]. These deals signal that the era of independent mid-tier streamers may be ending, replaced by a smaller number of scaled platforms competing for attention in an increasingly saturated market.

3 Subscriber Rankings and Platform Trajectories

Netflix remains the undisputed leader in global streaming, ending 2025 with more than 325 million subscribers worldwide, up from 301.2 million a year prior [1]. Its dominance is roughly double that of its nearest pure-play competitor, with more than twice as many subscribers as Disney+ [15]. Amazon Prime Video holds the second position with approximately 205 million paid video memberships globally [16], though its subscriber base is uniquely intertwined with Amazon's broader Prime ecosystem, which encompasses roughly 250 million total members [17].

The most notable competitive shift during this period has been the rapid ascent of Max (HBO Max). Through aggressive international expansion into markets such as Germany and Italy, Max grew from approximately 96 million combined subscribers at end-2023 to 131.6 million by end-2025 [18], effectively reaching parity with Disney+ at 131.6 million subscribers as of Q4 FY2025 [19]. Max continued its momentum into 2026, exceeding 140 million in Q1 [18]. Peacock, while smaller in absolute terms at 44 million subscribers by end-2025, demonstrated the strongest percentage growth among the major platforms —roughly 55% from end-2023 to end-2025 —fueled by NBA rights and bundling deals [20].

Paramount+ grew steadily from 67.5 million at end-2023 to 79 million by Q1 2025, an 11% year-on-year increase

[21], and reached 81.6 million by mid-2026 [22]. Apple TV+ remains the most opaque platform in terms of subscriber data, with estimates placing it at approximately 45 million in 2024 [23] and over 60 million paid memberships by 2025–2026 [24].

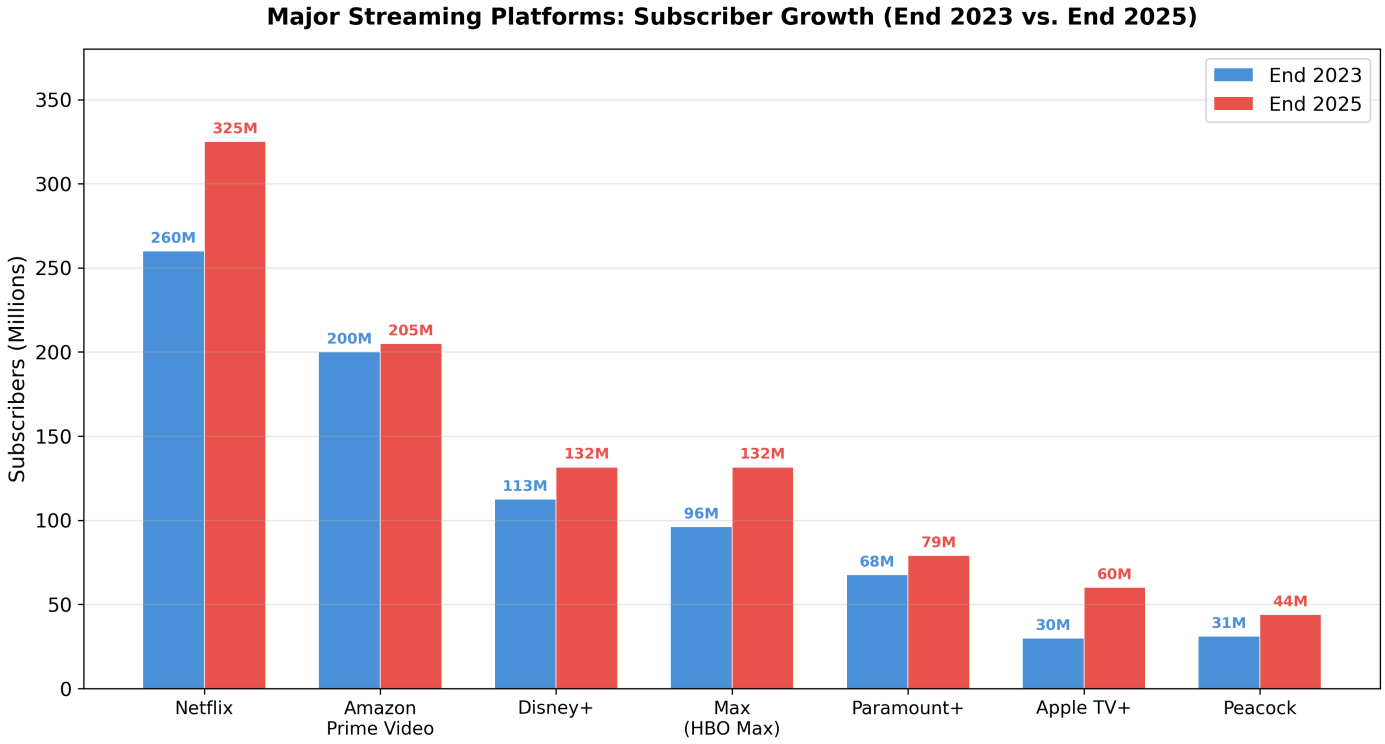


Figure 1: Subscriber counts by platform at end-2023 vs end-2025

Chart Explanation: This chart compares subscriber counts across all seven major streaming platforms at end-2023 and end-2025. Netflix's commanding lead is evident at 325 million [1], while Max's rapid growth from 96 million to 132 million represents the most significant competitive repositioning during this period [18]. Peacock and Apple TV+ showed strong percentage gains despite smaller absolute bases [25, 24].

Platform	End 2023	End 2025	Latest 2026	Key Growth Driver
Netflix	~260M	~325M	325M+	Password crackdown, ad tier [1]
Amazon Prime Video	~200M	~205M paid video	~250M Prime members	Prime ecosystem, NFL [16, 17]
Disney+	~112.6M	~131.6M	131.6M (Q4 FY2025)	Bundling, Hulu integration [19]
Max (HBO Max)	~96.1M	~131.6M	~140M+ (Q1 2026)	International expansion [18]
Paramount+	67.5M	~79M	81.6M (mid-2026)	Steady organic growth [21, 22]
Apple TV+	~25–35M (est.)	~60M+	60M+	Premium originals [23, 24]
Peacock	~31M	~44M	48M (Q3 2026)	NBA rights, bundling [25, 20]

Table: Major Streaming Platform Subscriber Counts, 2023–2026

4 Pricing Tiers and the Rise of Ad-Supported Plans

The pricing landscape has been reshaped by two concurrent forces: steady price increases across all tiers and the normalization of advertising-supported plans as the default entry point. According to research firm Antenna, prices for both ad-free and ad-supported services have risen on average more than 20% since 2023 [26]. However,

the pace of increases has moderated, with Ampere Analysis reporting that average price hikes fell from 24% of the previous subscription price in 2023–2024 to 14% in 2025–2026 [27].

Netflix's pricing evolution illustrates the trend clearly. Its ad-supported tier rose from $6.99 per month in late 2023 to $8.99, while its Standard plan climbed from $15.49 to $19.99 and its Premium tier from $22.99 to $26.99 [28]. Amazon Prime Video, which had no advertising at all in 2023, introduced ads in January 2024 with a $2.99 per month ad-free add-on [28], fundamentally altering the value proposition for its massive subscriber base. Peacock raised prices by approximately $3 in July 2025 ahead of the NBA season, reaching $10.99 for its Premium tier and $16.99 for Premium Plus, while introducing a new Select tier at $7.99 per month [29].

Service	Ad-Supported	Ad-Free / Standard	Premium	Notable Change Since 2023
Netflix	$8.99/mo	$19.99/mo	$26.99/mo (4K)	Ad tier up $2; Premium up $4 [28]
Disney+/Hulu Bundle	$12.99/mo	$19.99/mo	—	Bundled with Hulu as default [30]
Amazon Prime Video	$8.99/mo standalone	$11.99 standalone	—	Ads introduced Jan 2024 [28]
Max (HBO Max)	$10.99/mo	$18.49/mo	$22.99/mo (4K)	Ad-free up from $15.99 [28]
Paramount+	$8.99/mo (Essential)	$13.99/mo (w/ Showtime)	—	Showtime integration [30]
Peacock	$7.99/mo (Select)	$10.99/mo (Premium)	$16.99/mo (Premium Plus)	New Select tier added [29]
Apple TV+	$12.99/mo (no ads)	—	—	Single-tier outlier [30]

Table: Current Streaming Service Pricing Tiers (2025–2026)

Apple TV+ stands as the notable outlier, maintaining a single ad-free tier at $12.99 per month [30], reflecting Apple's strategy of using the service as an ecosystem complement rather than a standalone profit center.

5 Market Size, Revenue, and Regional Growth

Estimating the global streaming market's size requires careful attention to scope definitions, as analyst figures vary dramatically depending on what is included. For the SVoD-only segment, Statista projects worldwide revenue of approximately $98 billion in 2026 with a 5.89% CAGR through 2030 [4]. Mordor Intelligence, using a broader video streaming definition that encompasses AVOD, FAST, and related segments, estimates the market at $213 billion in 2026, growing at a 10.85% CAGR through 2031 [5]. These discrepancies are not contradictory but reflect fundamentally different market boundaries —SVoD-only captures roughly $100 billion, while the full video streaming ecosystem including advertising-supported and live content approaches two to three times that figure.

Regionally, North America remains the largest market, accounting for approximately 38–42% of global streaming revenue. Mordor Intelligence places North America's share at 41.85% in 2025 [5], while Statista estimates U.S. SVoD revenue alone at $35.21 billion for 2026 [4], with the broader Americas region reaching $55.30 billion in 2025 [31]. However, the fastest growth is occurring in Asia-Pacific, which Mordor Intelligence projects will deliver the highest regional CAGR at approximately 16.8% through 2031 [5]. Asia's SVoD revenue was already $32.64 billion in 2024 [32], driven by mobile-first adoption and rapidly expanding middle-class populations. Latin America represents a smaller but emerging opportunity, with growth fueled by mobile streaming and AI-powered dubbing that reduces localization costs.

6 Key Trends Reshaping the Industry

6.1 Ad-Tier Adoption and Monetization

The advertising-supported tier has evolved from a tentative experiment to a central pillar of streaming economics. According to Digital i research, 40% of active Netflix accounts were on its Standard with Ads plan by Q3 2025, up sharply from 26% in Q4 2024 [7]. Disney+ saw similar momentum, with ad-tier usage rising from 35% to 44% over the same period [7]. Netflix's ad-tier user base grew from 70 million monthly users in 2024 to 94 million in 2025, and reached 250 million by mid-2026 [33]. This rapid adoption reflects both consumer price sensitivity in an era of rising subscription costs and the platforms' success in making ad loads tolerable relative to traditional television.

6.2 Password-Sharing Crackdowns

Netflix's crackdown on password sharing, which began in the U.S. in May 2023, proved to be one of the most consequential strategic moves of the period. The initiative drove nearly 30 million net subscriber additions in FY2023, ending the year with over 260 million global subscribers [8]. The momentum continued into 2024, with the crackdown helping drive approximately 42 million additional paid subscribers [9]. Disney+ followed with its own crackdown in June 2024, registering a 31% peak increase in first-time app installs within four weeks of implementation [34]. These results validated the thesis that a significant pool of unpaid users could be converted into paying subscribers, though the one-time nature of this conversion means its growth contribution will inevitably diminish.

6.3 Live Sports as a Competitive Weapon

Live sports have become the most expensive and strategically important differentiator in streaming. The NBA signed 11-year media deals (2025–2036) with Disney/ESPN, NBCUniversal/Peacock, and Amazon Prime Video worth roughly $76 billion total [11], with Amazon paying approximately $1.8 billion annually [35]. Amazon's NFL Thursday Night Football deal, running 11 years at approximately $1 billion per year [36], established the template for exclusive streaming sports rights. Netflix entered the live sports arena with exclusive NFL Christmas Day games starting in 2024 [22]. These investments reflect a conviction that live sports are uniquely resistant to churn and can anchor subscriber retention in ways that scripted content cannot.

6.4 International and Local-Language Content

The geographic center of gravity for streaming content production has shifted decisively away from North America. According to Ampere Analysis, non-English-language titles represented the majority of Netflix's original TV releases for the first time in 2025 [14], a milestone that reflects both the platform's global subscriber base and the proven commercial viability of non-English hits. North America accounted for just 37% of global streamer scripted commissions in H2 2024, down from approximately 46% in H1 2023 [37]. Not all platforms have kept pace: Bernstein analysts note that Disney has underinvested in localized content, with only about 10% of Disney+ titles in foreign languages [38], which may partly explain its slower international growth relative to Netflix.

6.5 Bundling and the "Great Re-Bundling"

The streaming industry's "great re-bundling" accelerated in 2024 with landmark cross-company partnerships. The Disney+/Hulu/Max bundle and Comcast's StreamSaver bundle (Netflix, Apple TV+, Peacock) represented a strategic acknowledgment that consumers are overwhelmed by subscription fatigue [39]. The data supports this approach: according to Antenna, the Disney+/Hulu/HBO Max bundle led all plans with a 59% 12-month survival rate, outperforming Netflix standalone by 4 percentage points and averaging 28 points above its component services sold individually [12]. Disney further consolidated its position by acquiring a 70% majority stake in FuboTV, completed in October 2025, merging it with Hulu + Live TV [22].

7 Saturation, Competition, and Consolidation

The most significant structural challenge facing the industry is the approaching ceiling on subscriber growth in mature markets. According to Kantar, U.S. streaming penetration reached 96% of households (124 million homes) by Q2 2025, and for the first time since tracking began, overall streaming usage actually contracted slightly [6]. The number of new U.S. SVOD subscribers fell 33% to 18 million in 2025, down from 27 million in 2024 [13]. Industry-wide churn stabilized at approximately 4.6% in December 2025, a modest improvement from 4.8% a year earlier [40]. Netflix, while still adding subscribers globally, saw its net additions drop from approximately 41 million in 2024 to 23 million in 2025 [10], though it maintains the industry's lowest churn rate at approximately 2% [41].

Chart Explanation: This chart illustrates the sharp deceleration in streaming growth between 2024 and 2025. Netflix's global net additions fell from 41 million to 23 million [10, 9], while new U.S. SVOD subscribers declined 33% from 27 million to 18 million [13].

Competition from outside the traditional SVOD ecosystem is intensifying. YouTube captured a record 14.2% of all U.S. TV viewing in July 2026, nearly double Netflix's 7.8% share, and has held the top media distributor position for six consecutive months [42]. YouTube's share grew from approximately 10.4% in mid-2024 [43], representing a trajectory that positions user-generated and creator-driven content as a formidable alternative to premium scripted programming. Free ad-supported streaming television (FAST) channels are also surging, with viewing in Canada nearly doubling from 22% of online Canadians in fall 2024 to 41% in spring 2025 [44].

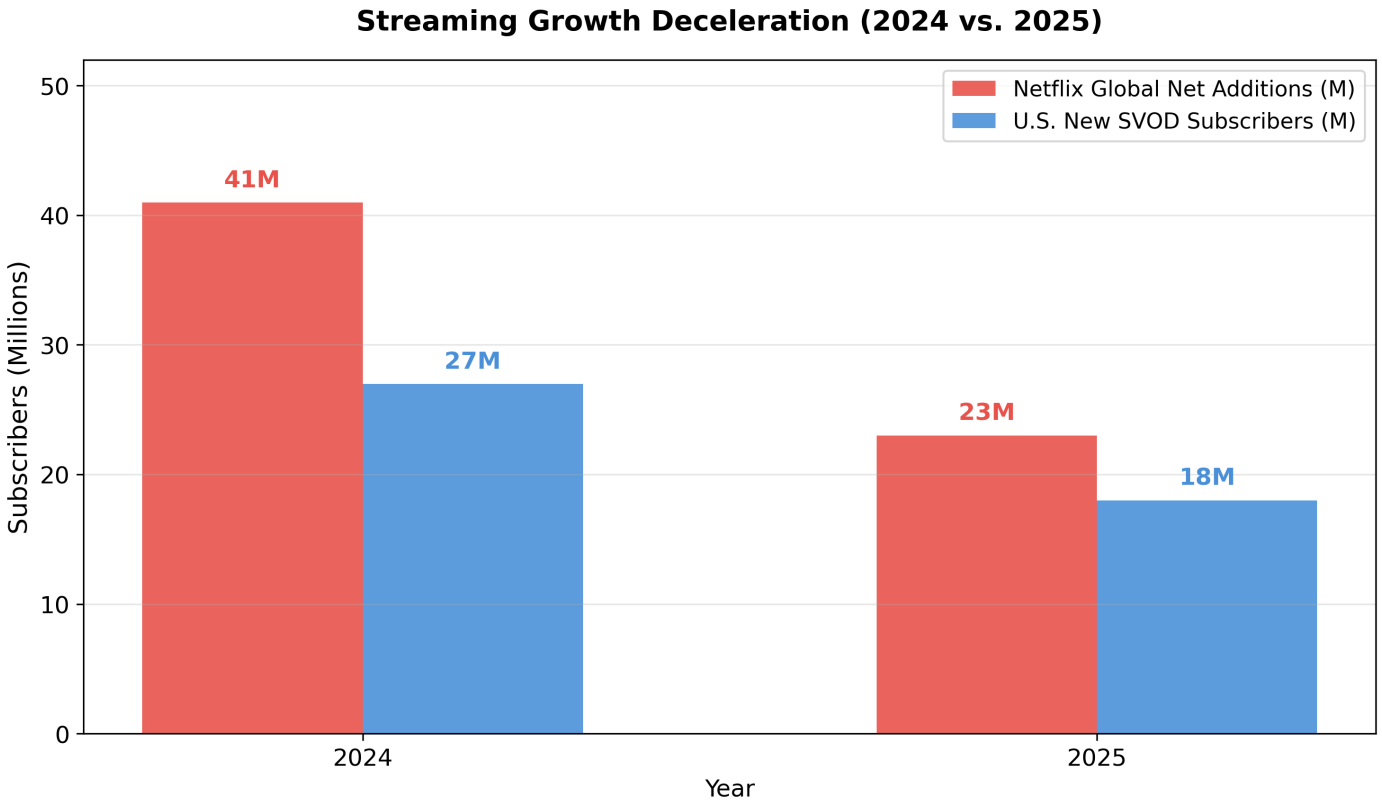


Figure 2: Growth deceleration in streaming

The consolidation wave represents the industry's response to these pressures. The Skydance-Paramount merger at $8 billion [2] was followed by the far larger acquisition of Warner Bros. Discovery at approximately $111 billion [3], creating a combined entity with over 200 million streaming subscribers. This mega-consolidation suggests the market is moving toward a structure with three to four dominant global platforms supplemented by niche or regionally focused services.

8 Outlook and Strategic Implications

The streaming market from 2023 to 2026 has transitioned from adolescence to early maturity. Several strategic imperatives have emerged for the period ahead. Growth will increasingly come from Asia-Pacific, where a CAGR of approximately 16.8% through 2031 [5] dwarfs the low-single-digit growth expected in North America. Advertising revenue will become a co-equal revenue stream alongside subscriptions, as ad-tier adoption rates approaching 40–44% of accounts [7] demonstrate consumer willingness to trade attention for lower prices. Live sports rights, despite their enormous cost, have proven their value as churn-reduction tools and will continue to command premium prices.

The competitive landscape is likely to narrow further. With Skydance Corporation now controlling both Paramount+ and Max [2, 3], and Disney integrating Hulu and FuboTV into its ecosystem [22], the number of truly independent major streaming platforms is shrinking. Netflix's scale advantage —with the lowest churn, the largest subscriber base, and the most diversified global content library —positions it as the most durable competitor, but even Netflix faces the reality of a market where the easy growth from password-sharing crackdowns and new market entry is largely exhausted. The winners in the next phase will be those that most effectively monetize existing subscribers through advertising, pricing optimization, and content efficiency rather than those that simply add the most new accounts.

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